



Active and Passive Voice

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Lecture Objectives

- By the end of this lecture, you will be able to:
- Define and identify active and passive voice in sentences.
- Understand the structural difference between them (Subject-Verb-Object relationship).
- Know when to use the passive voice effectively in technical and scientific writing.
- Know when the active voice is stronger and more appropriate.
- Apply this knowledge to make your AI-related writing clearer, more professional, and more impactful.

Why This Matters in AI

- As AI professionals, your work involves creating, documenting, and explaining complex systems. Your writing needs to be **clear, precise, and authoritative**. The choice between active and passive voice is a fundamental tool for controlling that clarity.
- **Myth:** "Scientific writing should always be in the passive voice."
- **Reality:** Modern technical communication values **clarity above all**. This means using the **active voice for strength and directness** and the **passive voice for specific, strategic reasons**.
- Think of them as tools in your toolbox. You wouldn't use a screwdriver to hammer a nail. Similarly, you need to know which "voice" to use for the job.

What is Active Voice?

- In an active sentence, the subject is the **doer** of the action.
- **Structure:** Subject + Verb + Object
- The Subject performs the action (Verb).
- The Object receives the action.

Examples

- "The **algorithm** (Subject) **processes** (Verb) the **dataset** (Object)."
- "The **research team** (Subject) **trained** (Verb) the **neural network** (Object)."
- "**She** (Subject) **wrote** (Verb) the **Python script** (Object)."
- **Why it's effective:** The active voice is **direct, clear, and concise**. It leaves no doubt about who is responsible for the action.

What is Passive Voice?

- In a passive sentence, the subject is the **receiver** of the action. The doer of the action (the "agent") is often omitted.
- **Structure:** Object + "to be" Verb + Past Participle + (by + Agent)
- The Object of the active sentence becomes the Subject of the passive sentence.
- You must use a form of the verb "to be" (is, are, was, were, be, been) + the past participle of the main verb (e.g., processed, trained, written).
- The "by..." phrase (the agent) is often left out.

Transformation from Active to Passive:

- **Active:** The algorithm (S) processes (V) the dataset (O).
- **Passive:** The **dataset** (S) is **processed** (V) (*by the algorithm*).

Examples

- "The **model was trained** on a massive dataset of images." (*Who trained it? The researchers. This is implied and not the focus.*)
- "Significant **accuracy was achieved** after the third epoch." (*The focus is on the achievement, not the achiever.*)
- "The **data must be cleaned** before training can begin." (*This is a standard procedure; the doer is irrelevant.*)

When to Use Which Voice?

- You Want to Be Direct and Clear:
 - *Passive*: "It was decided that the model would be retrained."
 - *Active (Better)*: "The lead data scientist decided to retrain the model."
- You Want to Take Responsibility or Assign Credit:
 - *Passive (Vague)*: "Mistakes were made in the data labeling process."
 - *Active (Accountable)*: "Our team made mistakes in the data labeling process."
- You Want to Make Your Writing More Engaging and Forceful:
 - *Passive (Weak)*: "The new framework is believed to be more efficient by the developers."
 - *Active (Strong)*: "The developers believe the new framework is more efficient."

Use the PASSIVE Voice When:

- The "Doer" is Obvious, Unimportant, or Unknown:
 - "The software **was installed** on the cloud server." (*It's obvious a technician did this.*)
 - "The results **were published** in a leading journal." (*The journal is more important than the publisher.*)
- You Want to Emphasize the Action or the Recipient of the Action:
 - "The patient's tumor **was successfully identified** by the AI." (*We care more about the tumor and the identification than the AI itself.*)
 - "The privacy of user data **must be protected** at all costs." (*The "what" is more critical than the "who."*)
- In Scientific/Technical Writing, to Describe Methods and Procedures:
 - "First, the data **was collected** from public repositories. Then, it **was normalized** and **split** into training and test sets." (*This is standard for a Methods section. The focus is on what was done, not on the researchers doing it.*)

Instruction: Identify whether the following sentences are **Active (A)** or **Passive (P)**. Then, for the passive sentences, rewrite them in the active voice if it improves clarity

- The convolutional neural network extracted the key features.
- The bug was fixed by the development team last night.
- It is assumed that the data is normally distributed.
- Our model achieved 99% accuracy on the test set.
- The user's personal information is never stored on our servers.

Answers

- A. (Already clear and direct.)
- P. *Active Rewrite*: "The development team fixed the bug last night." (Active is better here to give credit.)
- P. *Active Rewrite*: "We assume the data is normally distributed." (Much more direct.)
- A. (Perfect.)
- P. (This is a good use of passive. The focus is on the information and the action, not on "us." An active version like "We never store the user's personal information..." is also acceptable but shifts focus slightly.)
